A White Blouse
from The Road from Hiroshima
By Marc Kaminsky

Questions (Pg 15)

If I shriek
who will hear me . . .
if I speak normal
words in the normal order
Who will hear me
if I make poems
of what I saw and heard on the road
from Hiroshima
will I disturb
the dead
will I
be a merchant of our disaster
if I fail
to work all the horror
into a play
of voices in which the living and the dead
live again
who will forgive me

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INTRODUCTION

*****On the morning of August 6, 1945, the American B-29 bomber, the Enola Gay, dropped an atomic bomb on the Japanese city of Hiroshima. By that date an estimated 300,000 Japanese civilians had already died from starvation and bombing raids; but Japan's leaders refused to capitulate.*

The bomb exploded directly over a surgical clinic. And although less than 2% of the bomb's uranium achieved fission, the temperature at ground level reached 7,000 degrees in less than a second. The bomb vaporized people half a mile away, killing 80,000 people instantly.

For Americans the end of World War II appears to be in sight. For the Japanese, the horror was just beginning. This is the story of one of the people who survived the initial blast . . .

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A White Blouse (Pg 44-55)

1. Not aware
of what I was doing
I jumped
down to the track and braced
myself against it

somebody fell on top of me, screaming
a stream of pebbles lashed my face
trying to scream
my tongue fought an eerie

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weight and I couldn't
hear me

though I lay there shrieking with all
my strength

I found
I had stuffed a handkerchief into my mouth
and covered my eyes and ears
with my hands

2. Even now
I can't remember
how I threw off the bodies that boxed me in
and got to my feet
how I thrust aside
the passengers swarming
against me

how I climbed back onto the platform

I took one step, then another

but they came upon me
like lava they scalded they knocked me
off-balance they carried me
toward the burning cars

I hit against something hard

I threw my arms
around it
wrapped my legs around it

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not aware
of what I was doing

I held on
as wave after wave beat against me
smashing my chin
against steel
pulling my arms from their sockets

my whole body racked
and numb
I clung
to that pillar

3. Eventually it was quiet
I tried to open my eyes
I through: Lord
why have you blinded me?
I through: this is happening in a dream

then I saw a light brown haze
obscure everything
a chalky ash
fell through the air
there wasn't a soul on the platform

4. but their shoes! Hundreds
of shoes, left
and right separated
one from the other, confused
with clogs, strewn
among sandals and slippers

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and all overturned
or turning this way
and that, half-buried
under a chaos of
hoods and parasols –

only the shoes and hats, shorn
of their people!

like headstones and footstones
marking
the mass of
disappearance

5. and I
the only one left?

6. Black smoke rising
here and there
and Nakahiro-cho where my parents lived
already in flames

apologizing in my heard
I turned away from their home
to seek shelter.

7. Walls
on either side of the road town down
stone walls and fences
around each of the houses
demolished

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Brick walls, plasterboard, paneling, beams, blackened
window frames, rain doors, silk and gold
hand-painted screens

demolished!

leaving Yokogawa Station
I couldn't make out the road.

8. I walked through what had once been
a house

and shreds of someone's daily routine --
a clock, an ironing board, a photograph
of a sailor carrying a boy on his back --
were visible
under broken roof-tiles

pieces of white blouse and mattress
shocked me, hanging
from telegraph poles

I cried, "Anyone here?"

just as
I realized I
was together with the dead
woman in her bedroom

only we weren't really inside the house

all the walls between outside
and inside missing

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fire beginning to fan out before me
around me

everywhere was out-of-doors
and cemetery

9. bits of sky
fluttered into view, were swallowed
and spat out elsewhere

light dropped through holes in the whirling
cloudcover

and I was not alone

climbing through the remains of a bathroom

a boy
clinging to an emergency
bucket of sand

I went
toward him, I wanted
to take his hand

but he shivered away from me
hugging his bucket

he must have grabbed it
when earth went up
in millions of pounds of light

he walked unconsciously
pressing
this weight against him

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as if it could keep him
from floating off –

another strand of black smoke

10. And then
the debris was populated
naked
and half-naked men
and women
reeled against me

and a small voice under the wreckage –

only a pair of legs
could be seen

but a group
formed around the block of concrete
that sealed her in

pushing
in five different directions
we couldn't move it

"Forgive us," the others said

but I stayed
how long I can't say, praying
with her

"Help me
remove this stone," I pleaded

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as naked
and half-naked men
and women
collided and sank
amid the debris

then I too went away

11. One thing consoled me: my watch
was still ticking
it was 8:31! Only sixteen minutes
since the blast

I began counting footsteps
timing my progress

12. 8:50 A.M. near Yokogawa Station

Again
it comes back to me: the sensation
that this was only
my dream –

the thatched roof on fire

the peasant and his wife
moved deftly to salvage their household
furnishings, item
by item

but carrying
a great lacquered chest of drawers
they go stuck

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no matter how they turned
and angled it
they couldn't come through

so they stood facing each other
with most of their movable
goods in their arms

the man taking a half-step to the left, slowly
the woman to the right
then back again
as if in a trance

a slow, solemn, mesmerizing dance
in the open doorway
as the cottage burned

nobody stopped to help them.

13. Crossing Misasa Bridge, 9:15 A.M.

From a distance
I could see only the woman, lying
on her side
half-blocking
the other end of the bridge

and the refugees, as they approached
her, hesitated

one turned back
and ran toward the burning city

"What is it?" I cried

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but she didn't answer

"You'll get past this," I told myself
"if you don't look!"

but after counting a hundred steps
afraid
something bad was about to happen
I dropped my hands

and a baby girl
was undoing the buttons
of her mother's blouse

I drew close
and I saw
her clutch at the breasts of a corpse
she looked up at me
terrified

What could I possibly do for her?

"Go on," I said to my legs
"step over the body
and go on."

14. On the other side, 9:20 A.M.

A girl my age
was standing with vacant eyes in the middle
of the road
the great wound in her forehead
like a pomegranate
cracked open

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Instinctively
I ran
my fingers across the skin
of my face
when I looked
down at my hands
there was blood on them

so I got the mirror
out of my emergency kit
and located a small cut on my eyebrow

which I washed with spittle

then I did my hair
in a handkerchief
neatly
and went on.

15. 9:40 A.M. at the bank of the Nagatsuka

I was wearing a white blouse
with a blue pattern
miraculously it was free
of dirt
and it didn't get torn

everyone else
was in rags and hut
a woman
with the flesh of her side scooped out
and her ribs exposed

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seeing me thread my way through the crowd
in my nice clothes
asked, “Can you help me?”

but a man came between us
and admonished her, saying, “Everyone
has the same pain as you.
Endure it
and we will find shelter.”

16. 4:30 P.M.

I reached my aunt’s village

and I went to the river
to wash my clothes

the moment
I dipped my blouse in the water

it fell apart.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
ND State Qualifier

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Introductory information sourced from The National WWII Museum at https://www.nationalww2museum.org/war/articles/atomic-bomb-hiroshima

NOTES FROM THE AUTHOR: *The Road from Hiroshima is based on testimony of survivors of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Most poems are neither versions of the actual or reinventions of the real; they are collages in which the actual and the imaginary freely mix to give a vision of reality.*

This poem, “A White Blouse” is . . .

1. *Based primarily on a sequence of drawings with accompanying narrative text by Tomoko Konishi in Unforgettable Fire (Pgs 12-13)*

   See images here: https://visualizingcultures.mit.edu/groundzero1945/gz_visnav01.html

2. *And based on the narrative of the protagonist’s escape from Yokogawa Station and his flight through the burning city in the novel Black Rain by Masuji Ibuse (Pgs 37-38, 49, 107, 121)*

   Black Rain is the fictionalized account of a family who survived the initial blast and is now facing both physical and social complications from the fallout.

   Author: Masuji Ibuse
   ISBN: 978-1568364179
   Publisher: Kodansha International
   Date (Month/Year): Aug 2012

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